

United States of America



INSIGHT: By law, the actual records collected in a United States census must remain confidential for 72 years



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Although the demographic, economic, and cultural dominance of White Americans is firmly entrenched after over 400 years of settlement, the ethnic balance of the country is shifting. Barack Obama, whose father was African, became the first non-White US president in 2009. The African-American community, originally uprooted by the slave trade, has a strong consciousness. Less well organized socially but more numerous, and faster-growing, the Hispanic community is predicted to number over 25% of the population by 2050. Native Americans, dispossessed in the 19th century, are now among the poorest people. Constitutionally, state and religion are clearly separated. Conservative Christianity, however, is increasingly dominant politically. Living standards are high, but bad diet and insufficient exercise have left over a third of Americans obese.



THE ECONOMY

World's largest economy: well-established engineering and high-tech industries, huge resource base, global spread of US culture. Manufacturing is in decline as jobs are lost to low-wage economies. The combination of tax cuts, to boost consumer spending after the 2001 slowdown, and the rising defense budget for the "war on terror" drove the budget into a record deficit. Oil production was hit badly in 2005 by Hurricane Katrina, causing global price hikes. The "subprime" mortgage lending crisis of 2007 sent global stock markets plummeting. In 2008, Lehman Brothers bank crashed spectacularly, while other giants in the financial sector received huge bailouts. Further tax cuts and billion-dollar spending packages in 2009 attempted to lift the economy back out of recession, but the gaping budget deficit also needs to be brought under control.

FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: United States of America

DATE OF FORMATION: 1776

CAPITAL: Washington, D.C.

POPULATION: 315 million

TOTAL AREA: 3,717,792 sq. miles
(9,626,091 sq. km)

DENSITY: 89 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English, Spanish, other

RELIGIONS: Protestant 52%, Catholic 25%, other 19%, Muslim 2%, Jewish 2%

ETHNIC MIX: White 62%, Hispanic 13%, African American 13%, other 7%, Asian 4%, Native American 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: US dollar = 100 cents